

A changing trend

When it comes to communicating, especially in writing, there are two types of people in the world: those who are so articulate with their expression that they leave you transfixed by the beauty in their choice of words and overall quality of prose. They could be writing about something as mundane as the types of corrugated cardboard and you'd still be spellbound.

And then, there are those who don't rely on the "how" aspect as much as they do on the "what". To them the specific message, idea or concept takes precedence over its presentation. Such writers believe that anything that pulls the reader away from this central idea is superfluous and should be done away with.

How is this relevant? Well, we're in the business of communicating ideas and often we need to give considerable thought to not just the ideas themselves, but the way we convey them. It's the classic form versus function debate; it doesn't just apply to industrial design, UX and software. It applies to pretty much everything.

Take product reviews, for example. I've always been against supremely long reviews that go into too much descriptive detail. Most reviews, even in print, are accompanied by at least one image. On the web, the media is even richer. Forget about a picture being worth a thousand words, there are entire videos put out by the manufacturers themselves showcasing their products from every angle humanly possible. Against this backdrop, going into granular descriptions about what the product looks like, feels like, what it belies etc. is like waxing eloquent about the fact that the sky is blue in great detail. Everyone knows what the sky looks like. Incidentally, someone did an analysis of the great Indian epics and the works of Homer and found that for all the hundreds (maybe thousands) of mentions of the sky, no one bothered to state even for the record that it was blue. The ancients weren't colourblind, the fact was omitted because it was probably just so obvious.

So, what should reviews ideally contain? Should they be one-liners telling you whether to buy or not buy this product? Or how about keeping it even more simple – borrow from the Romans (not Facebook) and just give a thumbs up or down!

The downside to this is that no one will really trust such an assessment. There has to be a via

media between elaborate flowery prose (that doesn't amount to much anyway) and a simplistic "good" or "bad" verdict.

Take, for example, the OS comparison test we did last month as our cover story. We tested the operating systems on thousands of parameters and as a result of the empirical testing we arrived at the result. We didn't use flowery language or browbeat anyone into submission. We just left the evidence out in the open for scrutiny.

Coming back to the point at hand, I see this as a growing trend. Reviews and comparison tests will get shorter, videos will get slicker and perhaps, you may even have six-second Vine-like reviews. Take a look at The Verge with its recent "This is my next" initiative. No lengthy analysis, you just get the straight answer to what your next purchase should be. Our Top 10 lists on digit.in and the product comparison feature have served the same purpose for a long time. The slightly different comparison test layout you saw in the July issue was a precursor of interesting changes to expect in the magazine in the coming months. Of course, there will be more emphasis on scientific methodology, hard hitting facts and concise presentation. But to hell with flowery language and tedious verbosity!

A nod to this scientific way of doing things is Robert's little survey which tries to peg emotions associated with Digit in order to choose colours that have been proven to be linked with those emotions. So even the colours you'll see in the magazine won't be random. Take the 30-second survey here: http://dgit.in/Digit_is and also tell us what changes you'd like to see in the magazine.

I believe readers could do with less overwhelming language that nearly amounts to Shakespearean grandeur and lengthy descriptions of the obvious. Sure, as Digit readers, you want the details and scientific methodology to be present, but placed at the back; to be accessed if and when required – like a seasoned chef serving you your favourite dishes, with the best ingredients, sound recipe and an open invitation to walk into the kitchen. 




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Got feedback about this column?
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